



ture for the UN Security Council, Mansingh points out that Obama waffled and the long-winded statement came with no commitments.

Apart from China, another major foreign policy issue that figured prominently during the visit was the mounting uncertainty over Afghanistan. During the summit, Obama corrected the impression propagated by the US general in-charge of the American operations, that India's involvement in building infrastructure was not helpful as it antagonised Pakistan. While endors-

ing India's role there, Obama was unwilling to go further in terms of what else Delhi could do, including possibly training Afghan security personnel.

On Pakistan, Obama called for bringing the perpetrators of the Mumbai attacks to justice and in their joint statement the two leaders expressed "grave concern about the threat posed by terrorism and violent extremism emanating from India's neighbourhood, whose impact is felt far beyond the region." As part of their joint effort the two announced a Counter-terrorism Cooperative

Initiative to "expand collaboration on counter-terrorism, information sharing, and capacity building." But the impression remained that Obama hadn't pushed Pakistan as hard as India would have wanted him to.

The hope that the loose ends left in the nuclear deal would be tied up was belied. It was believed that the US insistence on some more reporting requirements and assurances on non-proliferation prevented the two sides from reaching a reprocessing agreement. The Indian side played it down, with Manmohan saying: "The president has reaffirmed that it is the common resolve of our two governments to operationalise the nuclear deal as early as possible. There are a few T's and I's that have to be crossed." On climate change, the US seems to have accepted India's position of not dumping the Kyoto Protocol and pushing for even stronger binding emission cuts for the developed countries while funding mitigation and adaptation measures for the developing ones. To lend the bilateral relations some immediacy, Obama accepted Singh's invitation to visit India next year.

For the Obama administration the timing of the visit could not have been less opportune, coming as it did in the midst of a shaky economy, 10 plus per cent unemployment, two prohibitively expensive yet unwinnable wars and a rancorous political fight over a piece of nearly trillion-dollar health-care legislation. All this was only compounded by slowly gathering scepticism about a young president's capacity to manage so much. Even some of his most ardent admirers have begun to feel underwhelmed by President Obama's performance so far. They say unless he and his advisers are engaged in some unfathomable long-term strategy, the signs do not look very promising. It is hard to see where India fits in all this, other than it being rhetorically described as "an indispensable global partner". The lingering feeling remained that when it came to relations with the US under the new administration, India was an "also-ran" behind China.

with Saurabh Shukla